

Understanding `getwd()` vs `here()` in R

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u. 22-June-2026

What does `getwd()` do?

`getwd()` asks: 'Where is R currently working?' It returns the current working directory. This can change depending on how you opened your project or R Markdown file.

What does `here::here()` do?

`here::here()` asks: 'Where is the root of this project?' The here package searches upward until it finds the project root, usually the folder containing the `.Rproj` file or Git repository.

Example:

```
here()      → /Users/rsteinitz/Documents/github/R Advanced Data Analysis
getwd()     → /Users/rsteinitz/Documents/github/R Advanced Data Analysis/week_2
```

In this example, the project root is the 'R Advanced Data Analysis' folder, but R is currently working inside the 'week_2' subfolder.

Why does this matter?

If you use a relative file path such as `read_csv('gorilla_data.csv')`, R looks in the **current working directory** returned by `getwd()`. If the file is not there, the code may fail.

Using `here()` is usually more reliable because it always starts from the project root. Then you can say: "go to the project root [parent folder], inside that, look for the folder 'Week_2' and inside that, look for the .csv file".

Example:

```
read_csv(here::here('week_2/gorilla_data.csv'))
```

→ This path will work regardless of which script or subfolder is currently active, because it starts at the parent folder and works inward.

Key Takeaway

`getwd()` tells you where R is currently working.

`here()` tells you where your project begins.